not only the realization of the Soviet-American agreement but also Soviet leadership of the communist world.[14]

Khrushchev's first reaction was to ignore Alekseev's advice and, instead of sending Castro a "warm" letter, resort to his usual bullying. In the letter he sent Castro on October 30, Khrushchev began on a warm note: "We understand your situation and are taking your difficulties into account." But he then went on the offensive, castigating Castro for his suggestion of October 27 to use nuclear arms against the United States. "Dear Comrade Fidel Castro," wrote Khrushchev, "I find your proposal to be wrong, even though I understand your reasons." He continued: "We have lived through a very grave moment; a global thermonuclear war could have broken out. Of course, the United States would have suffered enormous losses, but the Soviet Union and the whole socialist bloc would also have suffered greatly. It is even difficult to say how things would have ended for the Cuban people.… We struggle against imperialism not in order to die but to draw on all our potential, to lose as little as possible, and later to win more, so as to be a victor and make communism triumph."[15]

But neither Khrushchev's bullying tactics nor his logical suppositions produced the desired result. Castro responded next day, as defiant as ever. "I do not see how you can state that we were consulted in the decision you took," he wrote, responding to a condescending line in Khrushchev's letter that read: "[W]e consider that consultation took place, my dear Commander Fidel Castro, given that we received your wires, each one more alarming than the last." Castro did not conceal his disapproval of the Khrushchev-Kennedy deal and would not trust Kennedy's assurances. "The imperialists," wrote Castro, "are talking once again of invading our country, which is proof of how ephemeral and untrustworthy their promises are." Alekseev advised Moscow not to respond to Castro's letter, and this time Khrushchev listened. He had to come up with different tactics but could not change the strategy: without Castro's consent to inspections, the Khrushchev-Kennedy deal could not be implemented.[16]

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